



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Ascent Colorado Classical School of Grand Junction
School Website: <https://gj.ascentcolorado.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Ascent Classical Academy of Grand Junction (ACAGJ) demonstrates strong classical alignment across most rubric categories, with notable strengths in mission/purpose, curriculum emphasis, faculty quality, and parent/community partnership. Public materials repeatedly emphasize a classical, content-rich liberal arts approach, including a focus on virtue formation, classical virtues, and engagement with Great Books and Western Civilization through a Hillsdale-supported framework. Pedagogical practices show a mix of Socratic/seminar-style inquiry in upper grades alongside traditional teacher-led instruction and memory-oriented elements in lower grades. Overall, the school presents as CLASSICAL, with two categories showing only SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL elements due to remaining gaps (notably explicit liturgical/theological grounding and fully rested/Scholé-informed pedagogy in all grades). The aggregated assessment across the six categories supports CLASSICAL with strong evidence in Purpose & Goal, Curriculum, Faculty, and Parents & Community, and more tempered signals in Religious Foundations and Pedagogy.

Key takeaways: - Foundational aims center on virtue, moral character, and civic virtue within a content-rich Classical framework, reinforced by Hillsdale-supported resources and Great Books orientation. This strongly supports the CLASSICAL designation in most categories. Evidence: Mission/Vision statements, core virtues, Hillsdale-supported curricular philosophy, and Great Conversation references.

- Curriculum evidence includes liberal-arts emphasis, Latin, European and American history, classical literature, and senior-thesis capstone components, indicating robust classical curricula.

- Pedagogy shows a balance: upper-level Socratic/seminar/rhetoric emphasis; lower-level memory and drill elements; explicit statement of teacher-led instruction as a norm in some materials, which moderates to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL in pedagogy.

- Parents & Community are clearly positioned as partners and co-educators, with explicit calls for family involvement and accessibility to visits. This aligns strongly with classical-community expectations.

aggregates to a CLASSICAL overall classification.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school foregrounds virtue, character formation, and moral aims in its Vision/Mission statements (moral character and civic virtue; virtue-centered aims). - Core Virtues include Courage, Moderation, Justice, Responsibility, Prudence, Friendship, and Wonder, signaling a framework centered on virtue formation and reverence for beauty and moral ideals. - The Hillsdale College aspiration and the Great Conversation framing suggest engagement with transcendent ideals (truth, goodness, beauty) through a classical canon, even if explicit theological language is not foregrounded in public materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present (from the school's public materials): virtue, moral character, civic virtue, wonder, Great Conversation (and related Great Books ecosystem).

- Negative keywords present: none identified in the public materials regarding this category (no explicit liturgical practices or theology references).

Why this rating - The school clearly emphasizes virtue and moral formation as central aims, with an explicit focus on truth/goodness/beauty via Great Books-based framing, but it does not foreground explicit theology, liturgical practices, or a formal theological grounding in its public-facing materials. This combination supports a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL categorization for this category rather than full CLASSICAL, given the absence of overt theological grounding or liturgical/community worship language.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission explicitly aims to “train the minds and improve the hearts of young people through a classical, content-rich education” with emphasis on moral character and civic virtue. This foregrounds formation over narrow job preparation. - The stated purpose centers on forming virtue and wisdom and asserting the reality of truth, goodness, and beauty (as part of the classical aim). - The Great Conversation/Great Books orientation (via Hillsdale-supported program) signals engagement with canonical texts and enduring human questions, aligning with classical aims beyond mere information transfer.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: virtue, formation, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, Great Conversation, moral character, civic virtue.

- Negative keywords present: none explicitly indicating a secular or vocational-only aim; no hints at a reductionist, information-only goal.

Why this rating - The school's stated objective centers on formation of character and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty through a classical framework, not simply workforce preparation. This aligns strongly with Classical and supports CLASSICAL in this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Curriculum materials emphasize liberal arts through grammar, logic, rhetoric, and a tradition of classical education (Latin, Classical Literature, Moral Philosophy, Western Civilization). The upper-school materials include Classical Literature, Western Civilization, and a Senior Thesis, with a structured 7-period schedule and rigorous credit requirements.

- The program references core Knowledge sequences (K-8) and explicit phonics, plus a focus on primary-source documents, mastery of spelling/grammar, and direct instruction in a traditional, content-rich manner.

- There is explicit mention of Great Books/Great Conversation as part of the curriculum philosophy and Hillsdale-supported K-12 program, signaling canonical literature study as a curricular pillar.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, Great Books/Great Conversation, Western Civilization, Latin, Moral Philosophy, senior thesis, primary sources, content-rich curriculum, Great Books canon (via Hillsdale).

- Negative keywords present: none that would undermine classicism (no prominent mention of non-traditional/relativist curricula in the public materials).

Why this rating - The school publicly commits to a classical curriculum framework with grammar/logic/rhetoric, Great Books canonical study, Western Civ emphasis, and a Senior Thesis capstone. This aligns squarely with CLASSICAL in Curriculum.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Upper School indicates Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and use of logic; students are trained in rhetoric with opportunities to give speeches. This is a hallmark of classical pedagogy in higher grades. - Lower School reportedly engages in singing and chanting with regular review to deepen memory and delight, and a pedagogical emphasis on wonder (memory-based recall and delight in learning) is noted. This aligns with some Schol  -like, contemplative elements in early years but coexists with rigorous content.

- Materials also emphasize teacher-led instruction and a traditional classroom approach, with a Hillsdale-supported framework that includes professional development and coaching for teachers.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic, seminars, debates, rhetoric, Senior Thesis (capstone), teacher-led instruction, classical pedagogy, memory/review, contemplation (implicit in "Scholé"-style discussion in higher grades).

- Negative keywords present: some public materials emphasize a mix of traditional and non-Schélique elements (e.g., explicit mention of teacher-led instruction and lower-year singing) without a uniform rest-focused Scholé approach in all grades; no explicit heavy emphasis on full contemplative rest in all grades. This yields a partial presence of contemplative rest and slow pedagogy.

Why this rating - The presence of Socratic/seminar methods in upper grades and rhetoric emphasis, coupled with strong teacher-led instruction and a public Hillsdale-supported framework, signals a classical pedagogy in spirit but with mixed lower-year practices (singing/memory). This is best described as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, acknowledging strong classical elements in higher grades while noting less uniform implementation across all grades.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents teachers as central to the curriculum: "Develop Masterful Teachers," with a claim that the caliber of teachers is the school's strength; teachers are described as mentors who model virtue, skill, and knowledge, and as living curriculum. - Hillsdale-based professional development and coaching for teachers, including classroom observations and support for Hillsdale K-12 curriculum, indicate a strong, standards-driven, teacher-centered approach to classical education. - The school's governance and mission emphasize moral character and civic virtue, aligning teacher roles with model virtues and a "living curriculum."

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum, masterful teachers, mentorship, virtue modeling, professional development, teacher observations/coaching, Hillsdale support for teachers.

- Negative keywords present: none identified in public materials that undermine teacher quality or disposition; no negative descriptors of faculty culture.

Why this rating - The materials consistently frame teachers as the core of the educational experience, with explicit language about teacher quality, mentorship, and ongoing professional development within a classical framework. This clearly supports CLASSICAL for Element 5.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school portrays a strong partnership with families, emphasizes parents as co-teachers, and supports parent education and engagement via website content, book studies, and gatherings. Visitors are welcome, and parent partnerships are highlighted across materials. - Materials emphasize parent involvement, family engagement, and school-parent collaboration as part of the classical ethos; examples include discussions of partnership with families and a clear orientation toward family-centered education. - The overall communications framework conveys an insistence on parental involvement, transparency, and ongoing engagement with families.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-educators, family involvement, parent engagement, school-parent collaboration, parental leadership, community support. - Negative keywords present: none identified in public materials as obstacles to family engagement; no "family-disengaged" or "limited parent access" signals.

Why this rating - The school presents a robust, explicit partner-and-co-educator model with active family engagement, programmatic parent education, and accessible campus involvement, all of which align with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.

What Would Move the Needle

Not applicable since the aggregate rating is CLASSICAL. If the school sought to push toward a more uniformly rigorous CLASSICAL posture across all six categories, concrete steps could include: - Explicit public articulation of theological or liturgical foundations where appropriate, to strengthen the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations category without compromising the secular/classical strengths. - A more explicit, uniform "Scholé-like" contemplative/restful pedagogy across all grade levels, with documented intentional memory/recitation and slower-paced contemplative experiences in lower grades, to elevate Element 4 from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL. - Continued expansion of Great Books exposure and direct engagement with canonical texts in all grade levels (to further strengthen Element 3 and Element 2 alignment).

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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